





FILMS

FINDING THE **TRUE NORTH**

BOLLYWOOD DISCOVERED THE CHARMS OF NORTH INDIA LONG AGO. NOW A NEW GENERATION OF FILMMAKERS IS FOCUSED ON ITS UNVARNISHED REALITIES

In the past two decades, a sense of saturation with Mumbai locales has made Bollywood cast its net northwards, first to Delhi and then to the rest of North India. While running the geographical gamut from Rajasthan (*Gulaal*, *Shuddh Desi Romance*) as far east as Dhanbad (*Gangs of Wasseypur*), after Punjab, Bombay-based productions return most frequently to the Hindi-speaking towns of Uttar Pradesh: Kanpur, Allahabad, Lucknow, Bareilly, Mathura, Banaras. The films tend to fall into one of two broad categories: the 'gritty' politics-and-crime drama and the familial comedy that mines North Indian social and sexual dysfunction for humour.

Starting as early as *Haasil* (2003) or *Bunty Aur Babli* (2006), they have undoubtedly helped bring a specificity of place and language into mainstream Hindi cinema, whose settings had historically been deliberately generic. But much of what is unfolding in urban North India in recent

INTERVIEW

'You have to care!'



A theatre educator and activist with a background in documentary, ***Ritesh Sharma*** *won Best Debut Feature in May at the New York Indian Film Festival (NYIFF) for his film* Jhini Bini Chadariya *(*The Brittle Thread*), a raw portrait of life in today's Banaras. Extracts from a phone conversation:*

Q. Why Banaras?
I know the city. I'm from Mughalsarai, on the opposite bank of the Ganga from Banaras. My childhood was spent in railway quarters, where my neighbours were Muslim. I used to call the old lady Dadi. She shielded me from my father's beatings, like a real grandmother would. There was a Sikh family and a Christian family upstairs. It was literally 'Hindu Muslim Sikh Isai'; we'd do anything for each other.

Growing up, I spent time doing Nagrik Natak Mandali plays, chatting on the ghats for hours, *batiyana*, as we call it in Banaras. You couldn't drink beer in Mughalsarai, everyone knew you!

When I went back to write my script in 2015, a lot was happening in the country, and in Banaras. I started to feel, why is my Dadi scared? Why are my friends afraid?

Q. Your film has a Muslim weaver, a street dancer, an Israeli tourist. Was it always about this mix of people?
Yes. I went to neighbourhoods, recorded weavers, street dancers. I myself stayed in a tourist hostel on Nishadhraj Ghat, also in the film. I started in documentary mode. Gradually, the characters came.

Q. Apart from your

